



CHECK - PRE-SWIM FRAMEWORK

A PRACTICAL DECISION TOOL FOR OPEN WATER COACHES, BEFORE ANY SESSION BEGINS

C

CLARITY

H

HAZARDS

E

ENVIRONMENT

C

CHEMISTRY

K

KINETICS

Before any swimmer enters open water, five things determine whether the session should **proceed as planned**, be **modified**, or be **called off entirely**. Together they spell **CHECK**: Clarity, Hazards, Environment, Chemistry, Kinetics. This is the actual framework WOWSA coaches learn, given here in full.

THE COMPLETE 5-PART PRE-SWIM FRAMEWORK - FOR OPEN WATER COACHES, SWIM LEADERS & SAFETY-MINDED SESSION ORGANIZERS

C CLARITY

VISIBILITY & THE RESCUE CALCULATION

Water clarity determines how much of the rescue burden falls on the swimmer versus on you. In low clarity, you cannot visually confirm a swimmer's condition from a distance, which shifts real responsibility onto the swimmer's own visibility (bright caps, tow floats) and onto your positioning being close enough to compensate.

Field test: *can you see a submerged hand at wrist depth? If not, treat this as reduced-clarity conditions, not a minor inconvenience. Low clarity does not automatically mean cancel. It means increasing coverage and being explicit with swimmers about why bright equipment matters today specifically.*

REAL EXAMPLE

Lake Woodlands, Texas, is officially documented as a **zero-visibility venue**, confirmed directly by the local fire chief, requiring special dispensation for events to use it at all. A 2026 fatality there required sonar to locate the swimmer, and **it was not the venue's first**.

H HAZARDS

SUBMERGED RISK & VENUE DOCUMENTATION

Hazards are venue-specific and often invisible on the surface: submerged structures, debris, entanglement risks, marine life relevant to this specific water. A venue's history matters here. An artificial lake built on a former industrial or excavation site carries a real, specific reason to request a submerged structure and debris survey before the season starts, not just before the first session.

Known hazards get documented once, per venue, and re-checked periodically. Unknown hazards get treated with real caution at any new or infrequently used venue, not assumed safe because nothing has gone wrong yet.

REAL EXAMPLE

The **Maui Channel Swim** injury happened when an escort boat operated close to a swimmer. The propeller, not the boat's presence itself, was the hazard. **A known, avoidable risk category, not a freak accident.**

E ENVIRONMENT

TEMPERATURE, WEATHER & THERMAL LOAD

Environment covers water and air temperature together, not water temperature alone. Thermal load accumulates with both duration and effort: a session that is fine at 20 minutes may not be fine at 90 minutes, even in water that felt comfortable at entry. This applies at both ends of the range. Cold water risk is well known, but a hot day with warm water and high exertion carries its own real thermal risk, often underestimated because it does not look dangerous the way cold water does.

Rule: *if you are extending session length or intensity, re-check whether today's actual temperature conditions still support that plan, rather than assuming your usual duration is always safe.*

REAL EXAMPLE

Elite open water swimmer **Fran Crippen** died in 2010 after competing in water above 30°C (86°F) with no upper temperature limit in place at the time. **World Aquatics now caps open water events at 31°C (87.8°F) as a direct result.**



CHECK - PRE-SWIM FRAMEWORK (CONTINUED)

C CHEMISTRY

WATER QUALITY, ALGAE & CONTAMINATION

Chemistry means water quality: algae, discoloration, any visible or reported contamination. The absence of a posted advisory is not the same fact as confirmed safety, especially at a venue without formal, regular testing. A visible film or unusual color is reason to investigate before entry, not reason to proceed simply because nothing has been posted.

This is one of the easiest CHECK components to skip, since it rarely looks dramatic. Treat any visible change from normal as worth a real question, not a glance.

REAL EXAMPLE Water quality concerns forced multiple training-swim cancellations and an event postponement during the **2024 Paris Olympics**, when E. coli and enterococci bacteria levels in the Seine **exceeded safe limits after heavy rain**.

K KINETICS

TODAY'S CURRENT, TIDE & WAVE STATE

Kinetics covers current, tide, and how the water is actually moving today, not what a forecast predicted this morning. A simple field test: toss something that floats into the water near shore and watch it. If it moves parallel to shore, then turns sharply seaward and accelerates, that is a strong sign of a rip current. Identify it, map it, and either avoid it or brief it before anyone enters.

Current is one of the few CHECK components that can change materially within a single session, which is exactly why FLOW revisits it continuously rather than once at the start.

REAL EXAMPLE Rip currents are the leading cause of lifeguard rescues at beaches, a well documented pattern across coastal safety data, **not an occasional hazard**.

PUTTING IT TOGETHER: THE DECISION

CHECK is not five separate pass/fail tests. It is five inputs into **one decision**, made before any swimmer enters the water:

DECISION	WHEN IT APPLIES
PROCEED AS PLANNED	All five components are within your normal, acceptable range for this group.
PROCEED WITH MODIFICATIONS	One or more components is borderline. Adjust duration, coverage, route, or briefing accordingly.
CANCEL OR POSTPONE	One component is clearly outside acceptable range, or multiple components are borderline at once.

That last row matters more than it looks. **Two borderline components together are not twice the risk of one.** They are a materially different situation, since each one removes a safeguard that might otherwise have caught the other. This is exactly the kind of judgment the rest of the foundations builds on.

THIS IS ONE OF NINE

CHECK is the first of four real-time judgment frameworks in the WOWSA Safe Coach Foundations, covering the full arc of a session, from before entry through the swim itself to after exit, plus a dedicated module on recognizing when weaknesses in more than one framework compound at once.

CHECK → ABLE → FLOW → CARE

BEFORE ENTRY - AT ENTRY - DURING THE SWIM - AFTER EXIT

Alongside the judgment frameworks, five **Duty of Care** modules cover the professional groundwork underneath every session, with real, usable templates included, such as a risk assessment form and an emergency action plan:

EXPERIENCE & CREDENTIALS - POSITIONING - EQUIPMENT - DOCUMENTATION - INSURANCE & PERMITS

ONE FRAMEWORK DOWN, EIGHT TO GO. ENROLL IN THE WOWSA SAFE COACH FOUNDATIONS →